communities of hunter-gatherers who migrated from western or central China sometime in prehistory. Archaeological evidence suggests that Myanmar became host to complex cultures and societies sometime around 11,000 BCE. The earliest identifiable human inhabitants of Myanmar were the Paleolithic Anyathian culture, so-named from Anyatha, which is another name for Upper Myanmar. The Anyathian culture dates as far back as 11,000 BCE. The next identifiable human inhabitants bore similarities to the Hoabinhian culture, named for one of the first sites found in Hoa Binh province in neighboring Vietnam, which were characterized by the stone implements found during excavations.

Little is known about Myanmar during the Neolithic period and what is known is poorly understood. The paucity of evidence suggests that these inhabitants were hunter-gatherers as the absence of permanent dwellings indicate the inability to exploit their natural surroundings. Sometime between 11,000 BCE and 5000 BCE, the Anyathian hunter-gatherers transitioned from their relatively mobile existence to a sedentary lifestyle that saw the emergence of wet-rice cultivation in the alluvial valleys of the Chindwin, Ayeyarwaddy, and Thanlwin river systems, where Paleolithic tools have been found. Excavations at the Toungthamon site, located near the 19th-century city of Mandalay, reveal occupation dating from the late Neolithic period to the early Iron Age. Artifacts discovered at Toungthamon show that objects were acquired through trade, indicating affluence, and the specialization of craft production.

Irrigated rice cultivation appears to have begun flourishing in Myanmar by 3000 BCE. Then sometime between 5000 BCE and 2000 BCE, the rice farmers began domesticating cattle and pigs, slowly creating the beginnings of a sedentary agrarian economy. By 1500 BCE–500 BCE, Bronze Age settlements began to appear in the alluvial valleys of Anyatha. The discovery of a Bronze Age cemetery at Nyaunggan, east of the Chindwin River dates occupation to around 1000 BCE and indicates that the production of bronze or the trade in bronze had reached Myanmar by 900 BCE–600 BCE, although with the absence of radiocarbon dating, the date range could be extended to include the period 1500 BCE–100 BCE. The finds at Nyaunggan indicate the existence of a pre–Iron Age culture familiar with skilled stonework and the production of bronze weapons. The finds are also similar